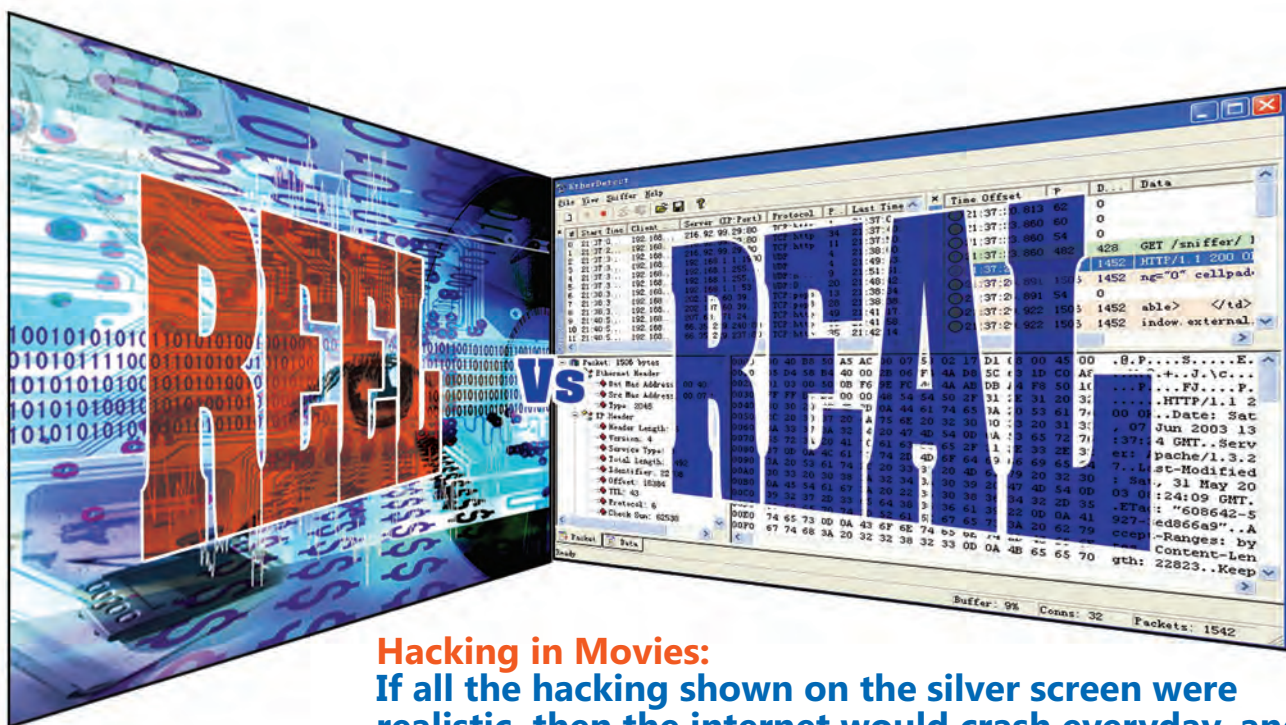




Hacking in Movies:
 If all the hacking shown on the silver screen were realistic, then the internet would crash everyday, and we would live in an Airstrip One-like society.

Aditya Madanapalle
aditya.madanapalle@thinkdigit.com

Hackers in popular culture are very different from hackers in real life, and we do a bit of mythbusting by comparing the portrayal of hackers on screen to hacker activity in the real world. Technology seems to run very differently on screen than in real life. Movies have generally moved on from showing blips of information on a voyage through cyber-scapes to showing almost real windows, and real terminals, but they still have a long way to go before reflecting the ground reality of technology. We look at some of the biggest mis-representations of technology on screen.

Untraceable

In *Untraceable*, the regular, run of the mill FBI agent sitting behind a console has almost god-like powers over the internet. Jennifer Marsh, the FBI protagonist, can shut down a site at a click of a button (called black-holing), get the username and password for any web site by just asking for it, and look at the Wi-Fi ranges of

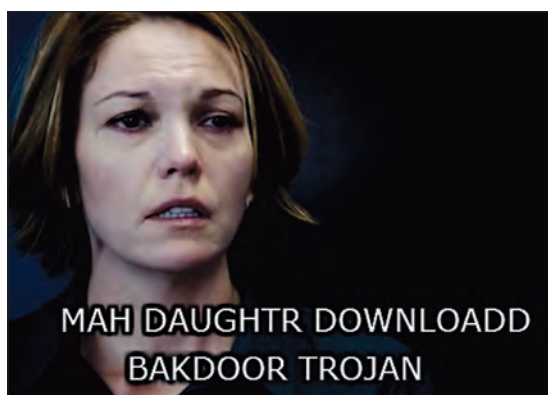
any router, in any home, using something that looks suspiciously like Google Earth. In the very laughable opening sequence, a hacker gets into a virtual machine trap (a honeypot) and steals passwords. As the passwords are stolen from a single text file, individual passwords are seen to get typed out on an on-screen keyboard! Mid-way into the movie, her own daughter downloads a "backdoor Trojan" in the form of a game, that was e-mailed to her by a friend. Apparently, FBI agents should go through our Internet Security Suite test. The movie has long boring sequences where a hacker on the internet

shows someone dying on webcam, as long as the site with the webcam keeps getting hits. Every time the FBI black-holes the web site, the web site switches the hosting IP to another machine.

Eagle Eye

Another movie that assumes that given enough money, technology can give you divine powers. The security agency that likes to pick names based on Norse mythology has a great operating system that breaks into cool waveform like transitions every time it wants to switch from satellite view to a live camera view.

Also, if you look at the maps carefully, random parts of countries seem to glow for no good reason. We wonder what is so interesting about the northern part of Arunachal Pradesh and the Rann of Kutch that it is dazzlingly brilliant, while everything else in India is dark. Cameras in the movie seem to have interesting shaped corsairs that don't really serve any purpose. And the beeps. Why should a perfectly normal aerial camera beep like a hyperactive car alarm? There must be something going on in construc-



The FBI agent who has not heard of an internet security suite